And not just the BJP, most political parties have woken up to the potential of the woman voter. Political analysts attribute the Congress's victory in the Karnataka polls this year to the promise of women-centric schemes such as a gas cylinder for Rs 500 and Rs 2,000 cash transfer. Last week, the party promised a stipend and free bus rides for women in Telangana. The Trinamool Congress (TMC) in West Bengal, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in Delhi and Punjab, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) in Tamil Nadu and the Janata Dal-United (JD-U) in Bihar have also rolled out several women-specific schemes and reaped electoral gains in successive polls. All this has made the bill even more significant in the BJP's electoral calculus. "The BJP believes it has successfully domesticated and become the custodian of women's issues in the country," says Prof. Mary E. John, former director of the Delhi-based Centre for Women's Development Studies (CWDS). "It's a signal to women voters saying the BJP cares as the party feels shaky about its grip on women voters after the Karnataka assembly polls."

As expected, therefore, almost all political parties have come around to support the women's reservation bill, despite misgivings about the lack of certain provisions and the competition to claim credit for it. Anticipating that the government could introduce the bill during the special session of Parliament, Congress leader Sonia Gandhi wrote to the prime minister urging his government to implement women's reservation in legislative bodies. Two days before the bill was introduced, the Congress passed a resolution at its Hyderabad Congress Working Committee meeting seeking its implementation. When asked for her opinion on the bill, Sonia Gandhi told reporters, "*Apna hai* (it's ours)," pointing out how the UPA government had got it passed in the Rajya Sabha in 2010. The Congress had raised the issue of women's reservation last year as well when Priyanka Gandhi, during her campaign for the Uttar Pradesh assembly polls, pushed for 40 per cent reservation for women. Other parties, including the Biju Janata Dal (BJD), the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) and the Ajit Pawar faction of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), had also joined the bandwagon demanding the revival of the 2010 bill.

THE OBC FACTOR

Whenever the women's reservation bill was introduced in Parliament—in 1996, 1998, 1999, 2002, 2003 and 2008—several caste-based parties such as the Samajwadi Party (SP) and the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) proved to be its most vocal opponents as they wanted specific reservations for Dalits and OBCs. They feared that if women's reservation was implemented without any sub-quota for OBCs, elite, privileged-caste women would corner the maximum benefits. This time, these parties and even the Congress have demanded a quota within the quota for SC/ STs and OBCs. While SP chief Akhilesh Yadav has sought a "balance of gender and social justice" saying the reservation percentage for backward, Dalit, minority and tribal women should be made clear, Sonia Gandhi has demanded a caste census first.

In fact, several non-BJP states have initiated caste surveys with the stated

HOW THE PARTIES FIELDED WOMEN

In the 2019 Lok Sabha polls, only TMC fielded more than 33 per cent women candidates

	BJP	Congress	BSP	TMC
Total candidates fielded	435	420	383	62
No. of women candidates	55 (12.6%)	54 (12.8%)	24 (6.3%)	23 (37%)
No. of women who won	40	6	1	9

Share of women in total candidates fielded in ( )

WHY THE BJP IS WOOING WOMEN VOTERS

- Since 1962, when the EC began breaking down voter turnout by gender in general elections, voting percentage among women has jumped from 47% to 67%, marginally higher than men
- But, till 2019, more women voted for the Congress at the national level. In 2019, for the first time, BJP became the party with the highest female vote share
- The party's vote share among men (39%) remains marginally higher as compared to women (36%), per a CSDS study